✦ BIOGRAPHY · LEGACY JOURNEY ✦

Muhammad Shabbir *Merchant*

Thirty-seven years, one arc of light — from a Dh 1,500 monthly salary to the UAE's signage standard.

SM

F NEWS · NEON MAGN

GROUP CHAIRMAN · CHAMPION GROUP

FOUNDER · CHAMPION NEON (1989)

CHAIRMAN · PBC DUBAI

TRUSTEE · WORLD MEMON ORGANISATION

Group Chairman · Champion Group
Chairman · Pakistan Business Council, Dubai

DUBAI · UNITED ARAB EMIRATES · 2026

1989	65K	150+	1,000+	100K+
CHAMPION FOUNDED	SQFT · DIP 2	EMPLOYEES	CLIENTS	SIGNS

THE BIOGRAPHY

From a Dh 1,500 salary to the UAE's *signage standard*

Early life & heritage

Born December 1958 in Karachi, Pakistan, Shabbir Merchant grew up in a family already anchored in the signage trade. His late father, M Y "Yousuf" Merchant, migrated from Bombay to Karachi in 1947 and became a pioneer of outdoor advertising and neon signs in Pakistan — first through a Lahore partnership, then building a wider reputation in hand-blown glass neon.

That inheritance of craft, discipline and a love of light-up letters would later shape the Champion story in Dubai.

Arrival in the UAE

In 1976, at just 18, Shabbir Merchant arrived in the UAE at the invitation of his elder brother Hanif Merchant — founder of what is today Emirates Neon Group. His first role was alongside Hanif, learning the fundamentals of the UAE signage market: how to price, source, install, and keep a customer for life.

His starting salary was Dh 1,500 a month. The habit he built around that paycheck — saving, re-investing, refusing shortcuts — became the financial backbone of the company he would one day start on his own.

> *"Customers are the backbone of any business. You can build with better machines, faster software or cheaper material — but nothing replaces a client who trusts you enough to call you back."*
>
> — SHABBIR MERCHANT, GULF NEWS SUCCESS STORIES

Founding Champion Neon · 1989

In 1989 Shabbir Merchant opened an 800-square-foot office in Deira and founded Champion Neon as a sole manufacturer of hand-blown glass neon signs — continuing the family's glass-neon craft on a new continent. Over four decades the workshop grew into the Champion Group — an integrated signage, digital and outdoor-media manufacturer with branches across Sharjah, Ajman, Abu Dhabi, Fujairah and Ras Al Khaimah, anchored by a 65,000-square-foot production campus in Dubai Investments Park 2.

CAREER JOURNEY

Four decades, *one arc*

1958

Born in Karachi

Born into the Merchant family; his father is a pioneer of Pakistani outdoor advertising and neon signs.

1976

Arrives in the UAE at 18

Invited by elder brother Hanif Merchant to help run his Dubai signage company. Starting salary: Dh 1,500 / month.

1976 – 1988

Apprenticeship in the trade

Learns design, pricing, fabrication and installation — building a reputation for reliability across Dubai's emerging commercial districts.

1989

Founds Champion Neon

Opens an 800-sqft office in Deira. The company begins as a sole neon-sign manufacturer — continuing the family's glass-neon craft on a new continent.

1990S

Expansion across the emirates

Opens branches across Sharjah, Ajman, Abu Dhabi, Fujairah and Ras Al Khaimah — becoming a UAE-wide signage partner.

2000S

Diversification beyond neon

Expands into LED, digital printing, outdoor media, branding and 3D signage. The Champion Group umbrella takes shape.

2010S

Industrial scale · 65,000 sqft

Acquires a 65,000-sqft facility in Dubai Investments Park II; installs advanced machinery, centralises design and production.

2019

Gulf News feature & documentary

Gulf News publishes "Shabbir Merchant — the multi-million neon magnate" — telling the Dh 1,500-to-millions story to a mainstream audience.

2020

COVID-19 pivot

Sons Shoaib and Shazil take operational lead; Champion launches COVID-19 Support Solutions with contactless signage and hygiene-focused displays.

2020S

Second-generation leadership

Shoaib Merchant heads sales & marketing; Shazil Merchant heads Champion Digital (LED, LCD and interactive technologies).

2024 – 2026

Chairman, Pakistan Business Council Dubai

Elected Chairman of PBC Dubai with a mandate to modernise bilateral trade practices, empower Pakistani start-ups in the UAE and expand PBC membership.

2025

Gulfood Manufacturing Pavilion

Joins the Consul General of Pakistan in Dubai to inaugurate the Pakistan Pavilion at Gulfood Manufacturing 2025 at Dubai World Trade Centre.

THE COMPANY HE BUILT

Champion *Group*

Champion Group has grown from a one-product neon workshop into an integrated signage, digital and outdoor-media manufacturer — widely recognised as one of the UAE's most trusted visual-communication brands.

NEON · SINCE 1989

Champion Neon

Hand-blown glass neon, LED-flex neon, illuminated 3D letters and heritage signage. The founding division.

LED & INTERACTIVE

Champion Digital

Fixed and rental LED screens, LCD displays, wayfinding, interactive kiosks. Led by Shazil Merchant.

PRINT & BRANDING

Champion Prints

Vehicle wraps, window graphics, exhibition stands, corporate branding — end-to-end design & fabrication.

OUTDOOR MEDIA

Champion Outdoor

Billboards, building wraps, pylon signs and large-format displays across all seven emirates.

Facility & reach · 1,000+ clients · 100,000+ signs

The Champion Experience Centre and production campus occupies 65,000 square feet in Dubai Investments Park 2, with branch offices in Sharjah, Ajman, Abu Dhabi, Fujairah and Ras Al Khaimah. Over 150 employees represent Pakistan, India, Nepal, Bangladesh, the Philippines and Africa. Clients span automotive, retail, food & beverage, hospitality, construction, corporates and banks. Annual turnover reported in the Dh 25–30 million range.

COMMUNITY & PUBLIC SERVICE

Affiliations & *institutional roles*

CHAIRMAN · CURRENT

Pakistan Business Council, Dubai

Newly elected Chairman of PBC Dubai, leading a modernisation agenda for bilateral UAE–Pakistan trade, start-up empowerment, and expanded PBC membership.

FOUNDING MEMBER

Pakistan Business Council, Dubai

Co-founded PBC Dubai — the primary institutional platform for Pakistani entrepreneurs in the UAE.

FOUNDING MEMBER

Pakistan Association in Dubai

Founding supporter of PAD — the largest social and cultural body for Pakistanis in Dubai.

TRUSTEE

World Memon Organisation

Trustee of the WMO Charitable Foundation — serving the Memon community through education, medical and welfare programmes.

IN THE MEDIA

Selected *press features*

GULF NEWS · SUCCESS STORIES

The Dubai Pakistani businessman who turned Dh 1,500 into millions

GULF NEWS · BUSINESS

Takes helm as Chairman of Pakistan Business Council Dubai

GULF NEWS · UAE

How a Dubai-based Pakistani family of merchants overcame COVID-19

KHALEEJ TIMES · SUPPLEMENT

Elevate Your Brand With Champion

KHALEEJ TIMES · KT NETWORK

PBC Dubai hosts successful annual general body meeting

APP PAKISTAN

Pakistan Pavilion inaugurated at Gulfood Manufacturing 2025

OFFICE OF THE GROUP CHAIRMAN

Contact

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THE FULL BIOGRAPHY · ONLINE

The Legacy Journey of *Shaikh Shabbir Merchant*

The complete illustrated biography — 12-milestone interactive timeline, Champion Group divisions, 16 press features, Gulf News documentary and full contact in one place.

KNOW SHAIKH SHABBIR MERCHANT →

azizsaif1967-afk.github.io/go/sm